

DELHI It was Tamil Nadu Chief Minister M. Karunanidhi's daughter Kanimozhi who once joked that her state could be divided into three sections—the backwards, the forwards and the Harvards. And this year, one of the most high-profile Harvard graduates from Tamil Nadu celebrated Pongal in capital style. Finance Minister P. Chidambaram hosted a Pongal lunch treating Delhiites to some genuine *sarkarai* (sweet) pongal, payasam and avial.

It may not have been as significant as AIADMK chief J. Jayalalithaa's 45-dish spread for Gujarat Chief Minister Narendra Modi, but the menu was succulent and the mood, equally shakarai. When asked why he had hosted a lunch for the first time in the four years he had been finance minister in the UPA Government, Chidambaram quipped, "Because election year is

Tuning in to FM



SHIPRA DAS

not far away."

Interestingly, just last week, Sonia Gandhi had reviewed all the flagship schemes of UPA along with the prime minister and

Chidambaram. The slowdown of Bharat Nirmaan was a matter of concern with the Congress chief. Later, before leaving for China, Manmohan Singh

PLAYING THE CAPITAL HOST: Chidambaram

held a preliminary Budget discussion with Chidambaram—a meeting of the Oxford blue with the Harvard white.

Congress sources say both have been asked to come up with a "soft Budget". Regardless, Chidambaram says when he demits office, he wants to quit on a note of continuous 9 per cent growth, "just like Don Bradman".

But with Chidambaram, it is never all play, not even when he is playing host. He chose the occasion to launch his personal website which will carry information about his portfolio and his constituency as opposed to the ministry site which is limited to policies. No surprises here, but there is no room for a Q&A session on his portal. Like the man, his virtual self too seems to have little patience for questions.

by Priya Sahgal

THE BUZZ OF THE WEEK

A Gujarat cadre IAS officer's appeal for justice after a molestation attempt by a heavyweight Union minister from the state has fallen on deaf ears. The minister is only hoping that the lady does not approach the National Women's Commission.

VOICES



"The people of Gujarat elected a man who would serve tax notice on them. From where else can I mobilise the money for the development of the poor?"

Narendra Modi, Gujarat chief minister

"We don't fight elections with any party. We fight elections on the basis of brotherhood of communities. If you want to call that an alliance, it is good."

Mayawati, Uttar Pradesh chief minister

"Marxists' goal is to achieve socialism to usher in a classless, oppression-free society. But it is not possible to achieve that end being in power in only three states."

Jyoti Basu, CPI(M) leader

"Public acceptance of the party has gone up. No one can stop it from coming to power at the Centre. Only BJP can save the country and make it strong."

Rajnath Singh, BJP chief

"I am disappointed that I am not continuing the tour between Australia and India in Australia. To err is human, to forgive divine, as the old saying goes."

Steve Bucknor, West Indian cricket umpire

